

for them. Red Hat hence could have only stable components in the Enterprise version as it was targeted at businesses. This meant there had to be a different means of ensuring support from the developer community. The Fedora project therefore came into being, where newer components, though possibly a little unstable, would be added for the enthusiast.

Why do people say “Red Hat” and “Fedora” in the same breath? Are they not two different distributions?

Red Hat Enterprise actually borrows inputs from the Fedora community. This ensured that a new and feature enhanced version would be available for free to the home user, while at the same time, the corporate user would get a stable, tried and tested version along with assured support, but for a price. Works well, you might think, but Red Hat is at the receiving end of various criticisms by open source purists for their pricing of the software or service.

The latest Fedora is Fedora Core 4. It is available for download from <http://fedora.redhat.com/Download/>. If you have a 64-bit CPU, choose the link that says X86 64, else choose i386. Fedora Core 4 is a 4-CD installer, with the total download size being about 2.6GB. So unless you are on broadband with no download restrictions, do not attempt to download it! Borrowing it from a friend is a better idea.

Fedora Core 4 offers you the choice of setting up either a KDE or GNOME Desktop or both. The kernel runs on Linux 2.6.11 and contains KDE 3.4, GNOME 2.10, and OpenOffice.org 2.0 (pre-release version). If you choose the complete installation, you will need about 7 GB only for the system files and applications. Installing typical components (such as music players, Web browsers, and OpenOffice.org) and leaving out developer tools, you can install it in about 2 to 3 GB. Installation is taken care of by Anaconda, one of the best OS installers available today. The Disk Druid tool, which allows you to edit the partition table, can be a little confusing for a newbie despite the on-screen instructions.